Other extensions exist to let PHP generate file formats on-the-fly, such as a popular extension that allows it to create Adobe Flash® movies.

Since version 3, PHP has integrated object oriented features. Version 5 built substantially on this limited functionality, and the language now has robust object oriented capabilities, including interfaces, exceptions, destructions, and abstracts.

PHP reached wide-spread popularity with version 4, released in 2000. In 2004, version 5 debuted, and it is now considered one the top languages used for server-side scripting.

No doubt much of its popularity is due to its relative ease to learn, and its notorious looseness. Arrays and variables in PHP are able to hold any type of object, variables need not be declared, and the syntax is remarkably simple.

Unlike many languages, such as C# or Perl, which have primarily a following of more generalist programmers, many PHP programmers know no other language. This occasionally causes it to be dismissed as a lesser language, but its growing popularity and the many robust and efficient sites built using it as a structure seem to dispel this myth.

PHP has occasionally been criticized for what are viewed by some as security flaws, in comparison to languages such as ASP. A lack of easily understandable error messages, a sometimes overly robust configuration file, and an obviously incomplete set of built-in functions are also pointed to as areas which could use marked improvement.

Development continues apace, however, and with each successive build, the language appears to address more and more of the concerns raised by its open-source community.

1.1.1 What Does PHP Do?

PHP can be used in three primary ways:

- Server-side scripting
- Command-line scripting
- Client-side GUI applications

Server-Side Scripting

PHP was originally designed to create dynamic web content, and it is still best suited for that task. To generate HTML, you need the PHP parser and a web server through which to send the coded documents. PHP has also become popular for generating XML documents, graphics, Flash animations, PDF files, and so much more.